# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Luís Montenegro, the leader of **Portugal's** centre-right Democratic Alliance—a group that comprises the Social Democratic Party and two smaller Conservative outfits—declared victory over the governing Socialists in the country's general election. Mr Montenegro reiterated his determination to rule without the support of Chega, a far-right party that came third, although his alliance fell short of a majority. Portugal had been one of the few European countries without a strong far-right presence in parliament, but Chega quadrupled its representation to at least 48 lawmakers in the 230-strong assembly.

Hopes were dashed for a **ceasefire deal** between Hamas and Israel as the holy month of Ramadan began. Defying a warning from President Joe Biden, Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, said he would press on with an assault on the southern Gaza city of Rafah. Egyptian officials, who have been trying to broker a ceasefire, said they remain in touch with both sides.

The annual meeting of China's parliament, the **National People's Congress**, concluded. Delegates rubber-stamped new policies, including on the economy. Those will do little to placate investors or citizens: the newly-set target of around 5% GDP growth for 2024 will not easily be met. Regardless, Xi Jinping, the country's president, used the event to demonstrate his absolute power.

The price of **bitcoin** exceeded $71,000, an all-time high. The cryptocurrency has rallied for five consecutive days and gained more than 60% since the start of the year. The surge has been driven by a wave of capital flowing into newly-approved bitcoin

exchange-trading funds. British regulators said on Monday that they would allow the creation of similar crypto-related securities.

**Catherine, Princess of Wales**, apologised for "confusion" over a doctored family photograph, which she said she had edited herself. Several news agencies withdrew the image on Sunday. It was the first official picture of the princess to be released since she had abdominal surgery in January. Many have speculated about her whereabouts in recent weeks, despite Kensington Palace stating she would not appear in public until after Easter.

**South Korea's** financial regulator said that 11 of the country's biggest banks and brokerages had poor regulatory compliance and a lack of consumer protection for sales of securities linked to the Hang Seng China Enterprises index. Potential losses from the equity-linked securities could reach 5.8trn won ($4.4bn) this year. Sales of them were paused earlier this year.

**"Oppenheimer"**, a blockbuster about the race to build the atomic bomb, won seven Oscars, including Best Picture. Cillian Murphy, who played J Robert Oppenheimer, was awarded Best Actor, and dedicated his prize to "peacemakers everywhere". Hundreds of pro-Palestinian protesters slowed traffic around the event. A handful of celebrities wore red pins to show support for a ceasefire in Gaza.

**Fact of the day:** Two**,** the number of third-party candidates that have taken more than 5% of the national vote in America's presidential election in the past 50 years. Read the full story.

*In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox*

Photo: AP

## Biden’s budget day

America’s Congress is still haggling over this year’s budget. But negotiations are about to begin on next year’s. On Monday Joe Biden will release his plan for the coming fiscal year. The president’s blueprint has no chance of becoming law because Republicans control the House of Representatives. But the budget is an opportunity for him to say what his priorities are ahead of the presidential election.

He is likely to propose a refreshed version of Bidenomics. The plan may feature increased spending on health insurance for the elderly, on tax credits for young families and on preschools. To pay for all this, Mr Biden will call for higher taxes on corporations and the rich. Republicans will call it a reckless tax-and-spend budget; Mr Biden will deem it essential to the country’s future. Fiscal policy may not be top of mind for most voters. But those who care will have two starkly different visions to choose between in November.

## Chaos reigns in Haiti

On Monday Caribbean leaders are expected to meet in Jamaica to discuss the crisis in Haiti. They have invited officials from other countries, including America, Canada and France. Gangs control 80% of Port-au-Prince, Haiti's capital. In early March they took over critical buildings such as police stations and government offices, and attacked the airport. The most prominent gang leader said the aim was to topple Ariel Henry, the prime minister. He has ruled unelected since the assassination of Haiti's president in 2021 and is very unpopular.

The Caribbean leaders may add to the pressure on Mr Henry to resign. He is in Puerto Rico, unable to return safely to Haiti. His resignation could make way for a transition government and then, eventually, elections. But any peaceful solution relies on the arrival of a planned security mission. Kenya has agreed to lead the UN-authorised deployment but does not yet have enough money or soldiers as countries hesitate over committing troops. With or without Mr Henry, Haiti's path ahead is treacherous.

Photo: Reuters

## Japan’s two-track economy

Japan’s economy grew by 0.4% in the last quarter of 2023, according to revised figures released on Monday. The initial estimates showed a 0.4% contraction, the second straight quarter of decline. That meant that Japan’s economy was technically in recession. Thanks to strong capital expenditure, the fresh numbers proved rosy enough to affirm that Japan was not. Nonetheless, consumption remained sluggish, casting doubt on the economy’s strength.

The real economy’s struggles stand in stark contrast with Japan’s stockmarkets, which are booming. Bumper corporate profits, a weak yen and rising shareholder returns have lured international investors back to Japan. The benchmark Nikkei stock index is up around 20% since the start of the year, breaking an all-time high set in 1989. For the economy to prosper as the stockmarket is doing, companies will need to raise wages enough to encourage growth in domestic demand.

Photo: Alamy

## Who can buy a leading conservative British newspaper?

Should an entity backed by a foreign government have a controlling stake in one of Britain's most influential conservative newspapers? That question may soon be answered by Ofcom, Britain's media regulator. Monday is the deadline for the watchdog to provide a report to Lucy Frazer, the culture secretary, on the proposed purchase by RedBird IMI of Telegraph Media Group, the owner of the *Daily* and *Sunday Telegraph*.

The prospective buyer is a joint venture between RedBird Capital Partners, an American firm, and International Media Investments. That is the investment vehicle of Sheikh Mansour bin Zayed al-Nahyan, the vice-president of the United Arab Emirates. He is known to many Britons as the owner of Manchester City, a successful English football club. Ofcom's report will cover whether the deal poses a threat to free expression and to news impartiality. The *Telegraph* has run many articles critical of the sale, which is also opposed by a large number of Conservative MPs.

Photo: T. Charles Erickson

## A media scandal on stage

“Succession” was a television show that dramatised a power struggle within a media empire. Its creator admitted that Rupert Murdoch’s real-life dynasty was an inspiration. Fans of the show, which ended last year, will probably enjoy “Corruption”, a play by J.T. Rogers. It is now playing at Lincoln Centre in New York.

The play focuses on a scandal at the *News of the World*, a now-closed British tabloid owned by Mr Murdoch. In 2011 it was revealed that journalists at the paper had hacked the phones of many prominent Britons. One victim was Tom Watson, then a Labour MP. “Corruption” dramatises Mr Watson’s efforts to take on Rebekah Brooks, a former editor at the *News of the World* who had become an executive in Mr Murdoch’s business. (Ms Brooks left her job owing to the scandal in 2011, but was acquitted of criminal charges and returned to work for Mr Murdoch in 2015.) A halo of screens hangs above the stage. That makes “Corruption” feel less like theatre and more like a Netflix series.

## Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

**Monday:** The Institutional Revolutionary Party ruled which country continuously from 1929 to 2000?

*He who rejects change is the architect of decay.*

*Harold Wilson*